Ideological Change in Indian Economic Policy Discourse 1961-2000[+]

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Abstract

I measure ideological change in India's economic policy discourse over the period 1961-2000, the decades spanning India's transition from central planning to market liberalization. Using a large language model (LLM) measurement pipeline, I analyze a sample of 11,523 text documents – 5,000 academic journal articles, 1,633 parliamentary committee reports, and 4,890 Rajya Sabha debate transcripts. I score each document on a five-point scale from strongly pro-state intervention (1) to strongly pro-free market (5) across five specific policy dimensions and one miscellaneous category. All three corpora exhibit a clear and sustained rightward shift over the period, though the timing and magnitude differ substantially by institutional setting. Academic journals maintained relatively higher pro-market scores throughout, while parliamentary and legislative discourse remained strongly pro-state through the 1980s before shifting markedly in the 1990s. The share of documents scoring 4 or 5 (pro-market-leaning) rose from under 1% in the 1960s to 11% in parliamentary reports and 28% in Rajya Sabha debates by 2000. Agriculture and fiscal policy/public sector enterprises show the highest levels of pro-state intervention. Industrial licensing, trade policy, and financial-sector-related documents show the greatest movement toward a pro-free-market stance.

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1. Introduction

How does ideological change in economic discourse relate to formal policy reform? To answer this question, we first need to measure ideological change. This paper uses India as a setting and measures changes in ideological rhetoric in Indian economic policymaking over the period 1961-2000. I construct and analyze a large-scale dataset of economic policy documents over this period.

This analysis examines the rhetoric and ideological orientation of academics, public intellectuals, and policymakers. Ideas may translate into policy through several mechanisms. In his essay, "The Intellectuals and Socialism," Hayek (1949) argued that second-hand dealers in ideas (journalists, teachers, popularizers, and commentators) serve as a transmission mechanism between academics in their ivory towers and the common currency of public opinion. Policy change, in this view, is ultimately downstream of shifts in intellectual fashion. Keynes (1936) wrote, "Madmen in authority, who hear voices in the air, are distilling their frenzy from some academic scribbler of a few years back." Lopez and Leighton (2012), in Madmen, Intellectuals, and Academic Scribblers: The Economic Engine of Political Change, extend these frameworks by mapping the institutional pathways through which economic ideas are produced, legitimated, and eventually adopted into law. They argue that a successful ideological movement requires three distinct actors: academic scribblers who develop the theoretical foundations, intellectuals who translate those ideas into accessible forms, and political entrepreneurs who mobilize them into policy coalitions.

In this analysis, I do not seek to establish a causal link between ideological change and policy outcomes. Rather, the goal is to measure and track the evolution of economic ideology across different institutional settings, providing a systematic empirical foundation for addressing the role of ideas in India's liberalization and the broader theoretical debate on this relationship.

The approach is motivated by the following premise: the ideological orientation of economic discourse is embedded in how documents frame the appropriate role of the state relative to markets. Two committee reports may both address industrial policy – yet one may treat licensing as a necessary instrument of development planning while the other treats it as a distortion requiring removal. The former would be considered to lean toward state intervention, while the latter would be considered to lean toward free markets. For this analysis, I develop and implement a rubric-guided large language model (LLM) measurement pipeline, building on the growing literature applying LLMs to large-scale document classification (Galiani et al. 2026; Horton et al. 2023; Korinek 2023).

I apply this pipeline to three corpora spanning distinct institutional settings. The first is a corpus of academic journal articles, drawn primarily from the *Economic and Political Weekly* (EPW), supplemented by the *Indian Economic Review* (IER) and *Social Scientist*. These journals represent the discourse of professional economists. EPW is not a strictly academic journal, however, and includes public intellectuals. The second corpus consists of parliamentary committee reports – the formal deliberative record of parliamentary scrutiny over economic policy. The third corpus is drawn from Rajya Sabha[1] debate transcripts, capturing the positions of legislators in India's upper house. To my knowledge, this is the first systematic large-scale ideological scoring in India's policy discourse including legislative debates.

The main findings are as follows. All three corpora exhibit a shift in mean ideology scores toward pro-market positions over the four decades studied. The magnitude of the shift is largest in Rajya Sabha debates, where the share of pro-market documents (scoring 4 or 5 on a scale of 1-5) rises from under 1% in the 1960s to 27.5% by 2000. Parliamentary committee reports show the most

[1] The Rajya Sabha is the upper house of India's bicameral Parliament, representing the states and union territories of the country. Unlike the directly elected Lok Sabha (lower house), its members are elected by the elected members of state and union territory legislatures, with some members nominated by the President of India for their expertise in fields such as arts, science, and public service.

persistently state-interventionist character, with the share of pro-market documents reaching 11% by 2000. Academic journals maintain the highest average score throughout but also show a notable dip in the 1970s — corresponding to the Emergency and the height of Indira Gandhi's socialist program — before recovering and accelerating through the 1980s and 1990s.

There is also striking variation across different policy domains. Industrial licensing and trade policy show the most pronounced pro-market shift, with both reaching mean scores above 3.0 (the neutral midpoint) in journals and Rajya Sabha debates by the 1990s. Agriculture remains the most persistently pro-state domain across all corpora. This domain heterogeneity tracks the actual reform trajectory closely: industrial and trade liberalization were the central focus of the 1991 program, while agricultural markets remained largely insulated from reform through 2000.

Some caveats to the results are in order. First, while I construct the dataset from the full population of these documents, I was only able to analyze a subsample of them given budget constraints. This sample includes 5,000 journal articles, 500 debates, and the entire population of relevant parliamentary committee reports. Second, the journal corpus is dominated by EPW (93.4% of journal documents). EPW has a historically center-left editorial orientation, but this should affect the level, not the direction of change. Additionally, EPW publishes opinion articles, essays, and letters from public intellectuals and businesspersons, and is not restricted to academic articles alone. Third, I use debates from the upper house of parliament because they were more accessible than those from the lower house of parliament, which could be incorporated in a future extension of the study.

This analysis would lend itself to evaluate ideas-based accounts of India's liberalization in 1991. Mukherji (2014) argues, through careful process-tracing, that technocratic economists embedded in state institutions were central to India's liberalization: their sustained advocacy within the bureaucracy and their growing legitimacy within planning bodies helped lay the foundations for the 1991 reforms.

Adhia (2015) similarly documents how changes in the ideas of Indian business elites — from suspicion of markets to enthusiasm for liberalization — preceded and enabled the political coalition that made reform possible.

The rest of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 describes the three corpora. Section 3 details the measurement methodology. Section 4 presents the main results. Section 5 concludes.

2. Data

2.1 Academic Journal Corpus

The academic corpus draws on full-text journal articles from three publications: the Economic and Political Weekly (EPW), the Indian Economic Review (IER), and Social Scientist. I obtain full-text data via JSTOR. The raw corpus contains 47,156 records from these three journals spanning 1961 to 2000.

EPW dominates the corpus. Originally published as Economic Weekly from 1949 until 1965, it became Economic and Political Weekly in 1966; the corpus thus contains articles from Economic Weekly in the early years (1961–1965) and from EPW thereafter. EPW occupies a distinctive position in Indian intellectual life as the primary outlet for policy-oriented economic research and applied economic commentary. Its editorial positioning has historically been broadly left-of-center, making it an important but not fully representative barometer of Indian economic thought. But we are more concerned with direction of the change, than the level. That is, even if the publication, EPW, is biased toward state-led development planning, trends in pro-market rhetoric should still be identifiable in the data.

Of the 5,000 articles in the analysis sample, 4,671 (93.4%) are from EPW, 187 (3.7%) from Social Scientist, and 143 (2.9%) from IER. The *Indian Economic Review* is the flagship journal of the Delhi School of Economics, included to provide coverage of the formal academic economics

profession beyond EPW's more applied remit. *Social Scientist* is a Marxist social science journal; and its inclusion captures the ideological range of academic discourse, including voices from further left of EPW's center-left orientation.

EPW is particularly well-suited for this analysis because of the diversity of contributors it attracted over the period. Its pages included academic economists from Indian universities, civil servants and Planning Commission officials, business figures and industrialists, lawyers, and independent public intellectuals. Contributors ranged ideologically from committed Marxists to advocates of market liberalization, making EPW a genuine forum for the full range of elite economic opinion rather than a narrowly ideological outlet. This breadth is what makes it a useful barometer of the direction of change in Indian economic thought, even if its aggregate orientation remained left-of-center throughout the period.

I apply a two-stage pipeline before scoring. In Stage 1, I use an LLM-based relevance filter to identify articles engaging with the state-versus-market dimension of economic policy. This excludes advertisements and corporate financial reports published in the journal. Of an initial 8,000-document sample drawn for relevance filtering, 6,229 (77.9%) pass the relevance threshold. In Stage 2, I score a random sample of 5,000 of these relevant articles on the five-point ideology scale described in Section 3.

2.2 Parliamentary Committee Reports

The parliamentary corpus consists of reports produced by select committees of the Indian Parliament with economic policy mandates. Committees whose work is primarily audit- or procedure-oriented, such as the Public Accounts Committee, the Estimates Committee, and the Standing Committee on Finance in its audit capacity, are excluded; I retain committees whose deliberations directly address economic policy substance. The raw corpus comprises approximately 12,147 committee reports with

identifiable economic content, of which 5,216 pass initial eligibility criteria of being a relevant committee-type. After applying a committee-type metadata filter (described in Section 3.1), 1,775 reports form the Stage 2 input pool. I attempt to score all 1,775, of which 1,633 yield valid ideology scores.

A structural feature of this corpus deserves note: parliamentary committee reports are, by institutional design, oriented toward scrutinizing government expenditure and regulatory conduct. Even the committees I retain, those focused on commerce, industry, agriculture, and public undertakings, produce reports that are structurally predisposed toward evaluating state actions rather than discussing market alternatives. Readers should interpret the persistently low ideology scores for this corpus partly as a reflection of institutional purpose, not only of ideological orientation. As with the journal corpus, the analysis prioritizes trends over levels: even if parliamentary reports are structurally biased toward pro-state framing, movement in their scores over time is still informative about ideological change.

The parliamentary corpus is heavily concentrated in fiscal policy and public sector enterprise content (47.7% of scored documents), reflecting the committee structure's emphasis on expenditure scrutiny and state enterprise oversight. Parliamentary committee reports are relevant to the question of ideological change because they represent the official deliberative record of the Indian state engaging with economic policy questions. They were produced by committees whose members included elected politicians, nominated technocrats, and senior civil servants. Although the reports themselves are institutional products rather than individual advocacy documents, they record testimony from witnesses (including economists, industry representatives, and officials) as well as the committee's own conclusions. Changes in the ideological tenor of these reports over time therefore capture the evolving orientation of the parliamentary and bureaucratic establishment, a distinct and important locus of ideological change relative to academic and legislative discourse.

2.3 Rajya Sabha Debate Transcripts

The Rajya Sabha is India's upper house of parliament, whose members are elected by state legislative assemblies rather than directly by voters. As a deliberative chamber with a strong tradition of substantive debate, the Rajya Sabha provides a uniquely valuable window into the ideological positions of India's political elite. Debates span the full range of economic policy and reflect the views of legislators, ministers, and nominated members (who often include economists, business figures, and intellectuals). Unlike parliamentary committee reports, which are institutional products shaped by procedural norms, Rajya Sabha debates are attributed to individual speakers and capture genuine ideological heterogeneity. Including this corpus allows the analysis to assess how ideological change in academic and deliberative settings eventually registered in the direct political speech of India's legislators.

The Rajya Sabha corpus is drawn from a comprehensive digitized archive of debate transcripts from India's upper house, covering 1961–2000. The raw archive contains 420,157 debate entries. I apply a keyword-based relevance filter on entry titles, retaining entries indicating engagement with state-versus-market questions in at least one of the six policy domains. This yields 6,326 relevant entries, from which I sample 5,000 for ideology scoring. Of these, 4,890 yield valid scores.

The Rajya Sabha transcripts capture a qualitatively different mode of discourse from committee reports and academic articles. Debate entries range from brief question-and-answer exchanges (typically 200–1,000 words) to substantive floor discussions. The comparatively shorter format means individual entries often present a single, clear argumentative position, a feature that tends to produce higher-confidence ideology classifications.

2.4 Descriptive Statistics

Table 1 summarizes the three corpora. As noted earlier, I use a stratified sample of the documents for analysis given budget constraints. The distribution of the corpora in each decade is proportional to the population in that decade.

Table 1: Corpus Summary Statistics

Corpus	Documents scored	Mean ideology score	% Score ≥ 4
Academic journals	5,000	2.22	15.9%
Parliamentary reports	1,633	1.81	6.5%
Rajya Sabha debates	4,890	1.93	10.1%
Total	**11,523**	**2.04**	**12.1%**

The three corpora exhibit notably different baseline ideological orientations. Academic journals score highest on average (2.22), reflecting the relatively greater market orientation of professional economic discourse even during the planning era. Parliamentary committee reports score lowest (1.81), consistent with the institutional incentives discussed above. Rajya Sabha debates sit between the two (1.93), though this corpus exhibits the most dramatic trajectory of change.

3. Measurement Methodology

3.1 Ideology Scoring Pipeline

I develop a two-stage LLM-based measurement pipeline. The pipeline takes full-text documents as input and produces, for each document, a policy area classification and an ideology score with a confidence rating.

Stage 1: Relevance filtering

For the journals corpus, I can use an LLM-based filter to identify documents engaging with state-versus-market questions. For parliament and Rajya Sabha, Stage 1 uses metadata-based filtering – committee type for parliament and keyword matching on entry titles for Rajya Sabha. This avoids introducing ideological bias through a relevance classifier that might systematically favor one type of economic argument. Procedural committees and debates in Rajya Sabha like audit documents and expenses estimates have been excluded already.

Stage 2: Ideology Scoring

For each document passing Stage 1, I submit the full text to a zero-temperature LLM prompt applying a detailed rubric. The rubric asks the model to:

1. Assign a *policy area* from six mutually exclusive categories: agriculture, industrial licensing, trade policy, financial sector, fiscal policy and public sector enterprises (PSEs), and other.
2. Assign an *ideology score* from 1 (strongly pro-state-intervention) to 5 (strongly pro-free market), using domain-specific anchors at each integer value for each of the six domains.
3. Assign a *confidence* rating from 1 (low) to 3 (high), reflecting how clearly the document's stance can be read from the text.
4. Provide a brief *explanation* citing specific content justifying the score.

The rubric instructs the model not to cluster responses at the neutral midpoint (3) and provides detailed, domain-specific anchors at each integer value. All Stage 2 classifications use `gpt-5.4-mini` at temperature zero, ensuring deterministic outputs, with a maximum output budget of 300 tokens for the structured JSON response.

The confidence score serves two purposes. First, it is reported as a data quality indicator alongside each ideology score. Second, in robustness checks I compute confidence-weighted means — treating the confidence rating as an inverse-noise weight — to assess whether the unweighted

averages are driven by noisily-classified documents. As I show in Section 4.1, the two series track each other closely, and the differences are substantively small.

The paper's rubric design – an integer scale with policy-domain-specific descriptions – differs from Galiani et al. (2026), who assign each article to one of five categorical labels (not a research article, other, efficiency, equity, or both) and combine LLM predictions with traditional text-based methods. I cite Galiani et al. as a precedent for applying LLM-based measurement to normative framing in economics documents; the specific rubric design with ordinal scores and domain anchors is a methodological contribution.

3.2 Scoring Rubric

The ideology dimension captures normative framing along the state-intervention versus market-mechanism axis. I measure expressed stance – that is, how the document argues, not merely what it discusses. A document that neutrally describes nationalization policy without advocacy scores 3; one that argues nationalization is essential for development goals scores 1; one that argues for privatization scores 4 or 5 depending on the strength of the advocacy.

For illustrative purposes, the anchors for trade policy are:

- **Score 1**: Advocates high tariffs, quantitative restrictions, import licensing, foreign exchange controls, and import-substitution industrialization as the correct development strategy.
- **Score 2**: Defends protection as necessary, with openness to selective export promotion.
- **Score 3**: Descriptive or explicitly balanced — acknowledges costs and benefits of protection without a clear normative recommendation.
- **Score 4**: Favors trade liberalization with some infant-industry protections retained.
- **Score 5**: Advocates free trade, full tariff reduction, removal of quantitative restrictions, and current account convertibility.

Complete rubrics for all the policy dimensions are in Appendix A.

4. Results

4.1 Overall Ideological Trends, 1961-2000

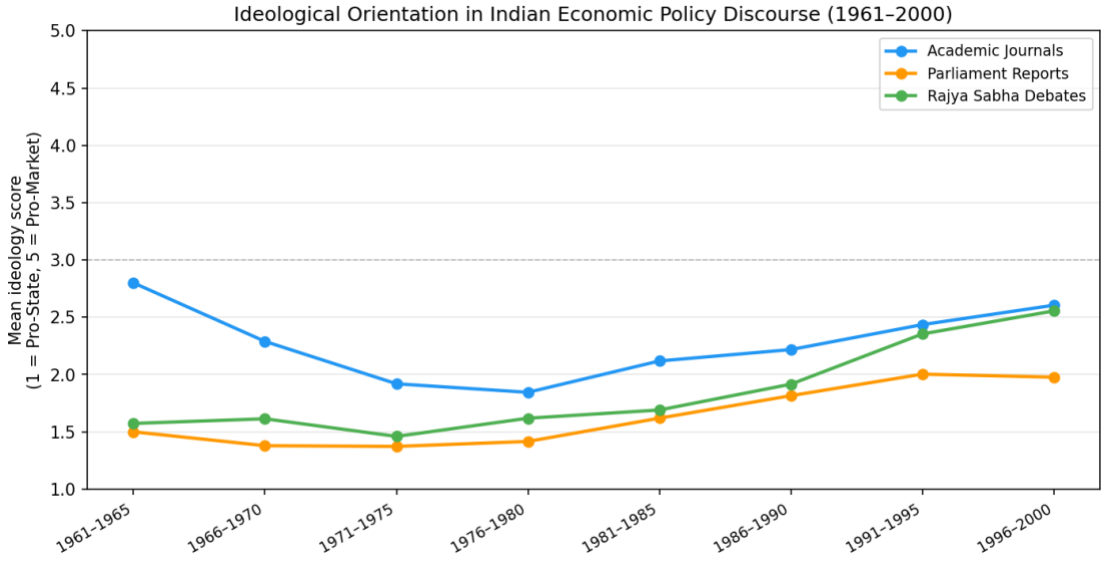


Figure 1: Mean Ideology Score by Corpus, 1961–2000 (five-year bins). Score of 1 = strongly pro-state; 5 = strongly pro-market. Dashed line at 3.0 = neutral midpoint.

First, all three corpora exhibit a sustained shift toward more market-oriented positions over the forty-year period, with the most pronounced acceleration occurring after 1986–1990. This timing is consistent with India's gradual liberalization literature, which identifies important precursor reforms — the partial industrial delicensing of 1985–1986 and the trade liberalization experiments of the late 1980s — as preceding the more comprehensive 1991 program (Srinivasan, 2000; Panagariya, 2008; DeLong, 2003).

Second, the corpora exhibit markedly different levels throughout. Academic journals maintain substantially higher mean ideology scores than either parliamentary corpus in every period. The gap is largest in the 1970s — a period of intensified state intervention including bank nationalization, anti-

monopoly regulation and foreign exchange restrictions, and the Emergency — when the journal mean dips to 1.90 while parliamentary committee reports reach their floor of 1.36.

Third, the trajectory of change differs across corpora. Journals show a non-monotonic pattern: 2.35 in the 1960s, declining to 1.90 in the 1970s, recovering to 2.15 in the 1980s, and reaching 2.48 in the 1990s and 2.61 in 2000. The parliamentary corpora show a more monotonic trajectory: flat through the 1970s and 1980s, followed by an inflection in the 1990s.

Table 2: Mean Ideology Score by Corpus and Decade

Decade	Journals	Parliament	Rajya Sabha	N (Journals)	N (Parliament)	N (RS)
1960s	2.35	1.39	1.59	530	163	672
1970s	1.90	1.36	1.54	1,311	214	884
1980s	2.15	1.67	1.78	1,477	196	1,600
1990s	2.48	1.96	2.38	1,518	596	1,581
2000	2.61	2.02	2.54	164	464	153

Notes: Mean scores on the five-point ideology scale (1 = strongly pro-state, 5 = strongly pro-market). The "2000" row covers only the terminal year of the sample; small sample sizes (especially for RS, N=153) mean these estimates carry more uncertainty.

Table 3: Share of Documents with Ideology Score ≥ 4 (Pro-Market Leaning), by Corpus and Decade

Decade	Journals	Parliament	Rajya Sabha
1960s	14.9%	0.6%	0.4%
1970s	7.0%	0.0%	1.1%
1980s	14.2%	1.0%	4.4%
1990s	24.1%	8.7%	23.3%
2000	29.9%	11.0%	27.5%

Table 4 presents confidence-weighted means alongside the unweighted series. The confidence weight is the LLM's self-reported level of classification certainty (1=low, 2=medium, 3=high). Weighting by confidence produces slightly lower means in all corpora — by 0.01 to 0.03 points — consistent with the model being marginally less certain when assigning extreme scores. Parliament is virtually unchanged (98% of its documents receive the highest confidence rating, reflecting the typically long and unambiguous nature of committee report text). The Rajya Sabha series moves the most (down 0.02 overall), as RS entries are shorter and more frequently classified at medium or low confidence (50% vs. 80% high-confidence for journals). In all cases, the weighted and unweighted trends are indistinguishable; subsequent discussion refers to unweighted means.

Table 4: Confidence-Weighted vs. Unweighted Mean Ideology Score by Corpus and Decade

Decade	Journals (UW)	Journals (W)	Parliament (UW)	Parliament (W)	RS (UW)	RS (W)
1960s	2.35	2.33	1.39	1.38	1.59	1.53
1970s	1.90	1.88	1.36	1.34	1.54	1.48
1980s	2.15	2.13	1.67	1.67	1.78	1.74
1990s	2.48	2.42	1.96	1.95	2.38	2.38
2000	2.61	2.58	2.02	2.01	2.54	2.51

Notes: UW = unweighted mean; W = confidence-weighted mean, using confidence ratings 1/2/3 as weights. Confidence distribution: journals 4.1% low / 16.3% medium / 79.6% high; parliament 1.2% / 0.8% / 98.0%; RS 18.5% / 31.9% / 49.6%.

4.2 The 1960s Pro-Market Current

The most striking number in Table 3 may be the journals figure for the 1960s: 14.9% of EPW articles in the first decade of the sample score 4 or 5 — explicitly pro-market. This is not obviously predictable

in a period associated with Nehruvian planning and near-universal policy consensus around state-led development. Who were the pro-market writers in EPW in the 1960s? The metadata linking reveals 79 journal articles from the 1960s with ideology scores of 4 or 5, and the authors fall into three groups.

The first group consists of business community voices: corporate executives giving annual chairman's addresses, which EPW published alongside its academic content in the 1960s. These include J.R.D. Tata (Tata Chemicals, 1969; Tata Iron and Steel, 1967), S.L. Kirloskar (Kirloskar Oil Engines, 1969), G.L. Mehta (ICICI chairman, 1969), and industry association presidents such as D.C. Kothari of the Indian Sugar Mills Association (1969). These are not academic arguments for market liberalization but business advocacy for deregulation. EPW's practice of publishing corporate annual report content was common in the 1960s and declined subsequently.

The second group consists of professional economists and policy analysts, including I.S. Gulati (trade competitiveness, 1968), H.T. Parekh (financial sector, 1967 — later founder of HDFC), G.C. da Costa (trade policy, 1967), Sudhir Mulji (1966), and A.D. Karve (agriculture, 1968). These represent a genuine intellectual pro-market minority operating within EPW's otherwise left-leaning publishing environment.

The third group is anonymous or pseudonymous: contributors writing under pen names such as *Arthagnani*, *Flibbertigibbet*, *Nishtar*, and *Hansavivek*, which was a common EPW practice for editorial commentary and market reports. Many of these appear to be commodity market news items (steel prices, groundnut harvests, tea exports) that the model correctly identifies as containing pro-market content but that are not intellectual arguments in the conventional sense. The 1970s dip from 14.9% to 7.0% likely reflects EPW reducing its corporate chairman address content.

The legislative corpora show essentially zero pro-market documents throughout the 1980s (0.6%, 0.0%, and 1.0% for parliament across the first three decades; 0.4%, 1.1%, and 4.4% for RS).

The 1990s represent a structural break: pro-market shares roughly double or more in all three corpora within a single decade, with the Rajya Sabha showing the most dramatic absolute increase (from 4.4% to 23.3%).

4.3 Heterogeneity by Policy Domain

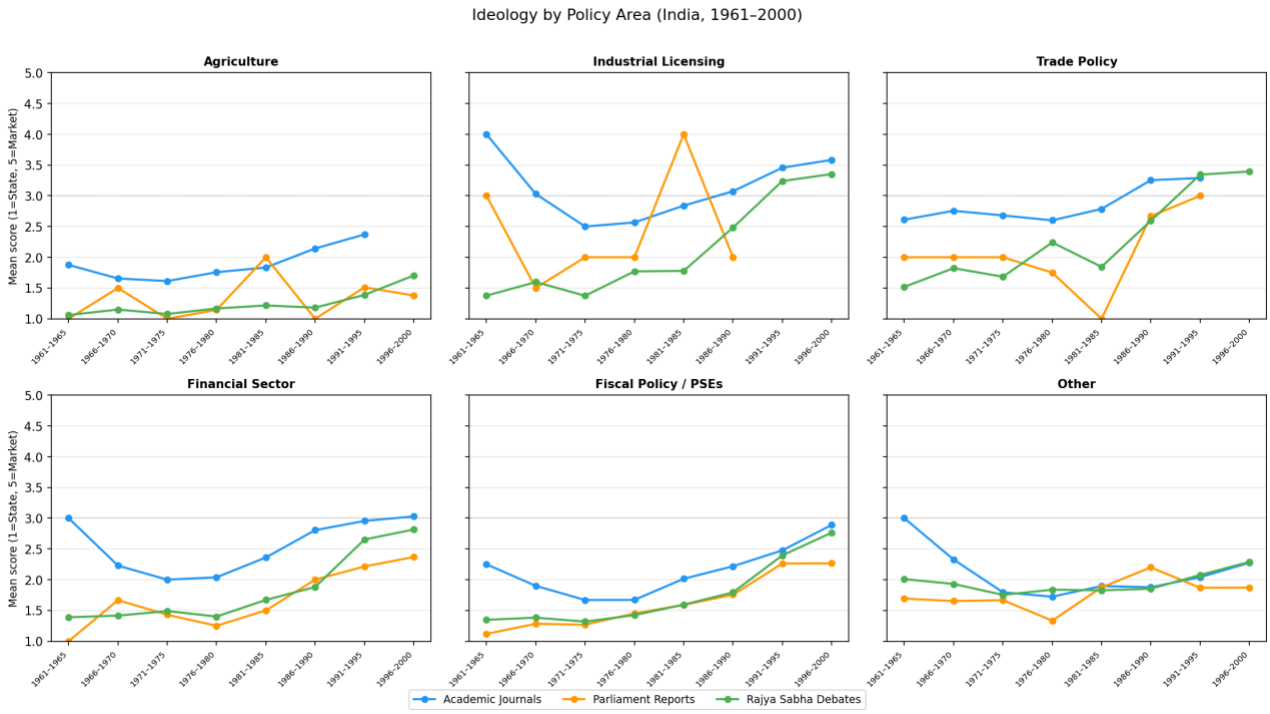


Figure 2: Mean Ideology Score by Policy Area, 1961–2000. Each panel shows one of the six policy domains; lines represent the three corpora.

Figure 2 decomposes the ideological trends by the six policy domains.

Industrial licensing and trade policy exhibit the most dramatic shifts and by the 1990s are the only domains to cross the neutral midpoint (3.0) in journals and legislative debates. In journals, mean ideology scores for industrial licensing reach 3.45 in the 1990s; trade policy reaches 3.26. In Rajya Sabha debates, industrial licensing reaches 3.26 and trade policy 3.37 in the 1990s — indicating that even the legislative register, typically the most pro-state, reflected a genuine shift in how these policy areas were discussed. The transformation of professional consensus on the License Raj — from

necessary development planning instrument in the 1960s to rent-seeking machine in the 1990s — is legible in these time series.

Agriculture is the most persistently pro-state domain across all three corpora throughout the period. Mean scores remain below 2.0 in all corpora through the 1990s. The minimal movement toward free-markets here — compared to industrial and trade policy — is consistent with the broader pattern of Indian reform: agricultural markets were substantially less liberalized than industrial and financial markets through the end of the 1990s, and the political economy of agricultural subsidies and procurement pricing made reform particularly difficult.

Financial sector discourse shows a more gradual liberalization trajectory. The financial sector was the focus of early and aggressive interventionism — bank nationalization in 1969, directed credit mandates, extensive interest rate regulation — and remained heavily state-dominated through the 1980s. The data capture this sequencing: financial sector mean scores in journals reach 2.95 in the 1990s, approaching the neutral midpoint but not crossing it until 2000 (3.22), consistent with the concentration of financial liberalization in the post-Narasimham Committee period after 1992–93.

Fiscal policy and public sector enterprises show the largest share of documents in the parliamentary corpus (47.7%). Despite being structurally the most state-oriented domain by the nature of parliamentary oversight, this domain also shows a meaningful shift in the 1990s — partly reflecting the emergence of disinvestment as a legitimate policy option after the establishment of the Disinvestment Commission in 1996.

5. Conclusion

This paper provides the first systematic, large-scale measurement of ideological change in Indian economic policy discourse over the four decades spanning 1961 to 2000. Applying a rubric-guided LLM measurement pipeline to 11,523 documents across academic journals, parliamentary committee

reports, and Rajya Sabha debates, I document a clear and sustained shift from pro-state to more market-oriented framing across all three institutional settings.

The magnitude and timing of this shift vary substantially across corpora. Academic discourse shows the earliest evidence of liberalization-oriented thinking, with a pre-existing but politically suppressed pro-market strand in the 1960s, a contraction in the 1970s, and recovery and acceleration beginning in the 1980s. Legislative rhetoric shifts more sharply but primarily after the formal liberalization program of 1991. This sequencing is consistent with a crisis-driven reform model, though I cannot rule out independent responses to common external shocks as an alternative explanation.

The domain heterogeneity — industrial licensing and trade policy liberalizing fastest; agriculture persistently state-oriented — tracks the actual reform trajectory closely and provides a measure of construct validity for the LLM-based scores.

Several limitations should inform interpretation. First, the journal corpus is dominated by EPW (93.4%), whose center-left orientation means I am measuring ideological movement within one important but limited strand of Indian economic thought. Pro-market voices outside EPW — in outlets like Eastern Economist, Swarajya, or the Forum of Free Enterprise pamphlet literature — are not represented. Extending the corpus to include these sources would provide a more complete picture of the ideological landscape. Second, I do not yet have author-level analysis: who the 1960s pro-market writers were, and whether individual economists shifted their positions or whether compositional changes drove the aggregate trends, remains unknown. Third, the LLM-based scores are subject to measurement error, and a validation exercise may help address this.

Despite these limitations, this paper demonstrates the promise of LLM-based measurement for studying the evolution of economic ideas. The Rajya Sabha corpus in particular, to my knowledge

the first large-scale ideological analysis of Indian legislative debates, offers a window into political-economic discourse that complements both academic journals and formal policy documents. Extensions to longer time horizons, other countries, or other ideological dimensions are natural avenues for future work.

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Appendix A: Full Scoring Rubric

The rubric below is submitted verbatim as part of the LLM prompt for every Stage 2 classification. Documents are classified using `gpt-5.4-mini` at temperature 0. The `{corpus_label}`, `{year}`, and `{text}` fields are filled at runtime.

STEP 1 — POLICY AREA

Assign exactly ONE primary policy area (the most central topic):

- **agriculture**: MSP/procurement prices, food subsidy, PDS, agri credit, irrigation, land reform, fertilizer subsidies, crop insurance, agricultural markets, APMC
- **industrial_licensing**: License Raj, MRTP, SSI/small-scale reservations, industrial policy, capacity licensing, DGTD, Monopolies Act, permit system, factory legislation
- **trade_policy**: tariffs, quantitative restrictions (QRs), import licensing, EXIM policy, GATT/WTO, export controls, foreign exchange controls on trade, import substitution, canalised imports.
- **financial_sector**: bank nationalization, directed credit, priority sector lending, FERA, capital controls, FIIs, interest rate regulation, RBI monetary policy, NBFCs, insurance nationalization, international capital flows, devaluation/exchange rate.
- **fiscal_pse**: government expenditure, deficit financing, Five-Year Plans, nationalization, PSU performance, disinvestment, privatization, budget policy, public investment, subsidies (non-agri)
- **other**: relevant to state-vs-market debate but not fitting the above (e.g., labor policy, health, education, infrastructure, general macroeconomic stabilization, regional policy)

STEP 2 — IDEOLOGY SCORE

Score the document's ideological stance: 1 = strongly pro-state-intervention, 5 = strongly pro-free market. Use the FULL 1–5 scale. Reserve 3 only for documents that are genuinely balanced, purely descriptive, or explicitly advocate a mixed approach.

Agriculture:

1: Advocates MSP/procurement, input subsidies, state marketing boards, nationalized agri credit, restrictions on private grain trade, land redistribution

2: Supports government intervention as the main solution; acknowledges markets but favors state mechanisms

3: Descriptive or explicitly balanced/mixed approach

4: Favours some decontrol, private sector participation, market-linked prices with farmer welfare caveats

5: Advocates decontrol of agricultural markets, removal of Essential Commodities Act, private procurement/storage, export liberalization, contract farming

Industrial Licensing:

1: Defends License Raj as necessary; MRTP/FERA as essential; small-scale industries reservations as critical; import substitution as the correct model

2: Supports licensing with selective rationalization; cautious about deregulation

3: Descriptive analysis without normative stance

4: Favours significant liberalization, FDI in manufacturing, retains some protection

5: Advocates abolition of licensing and quotas, removal of MRTP constraints, full FDI

Trade Policy:

1: Advocates high tariffs, QRs, import licensing, forex controls, import substitution industrialization

2: Defends protection with openness to selective export promotion

3: Descriptive or balanced (acknowledges costs and benefits of protection)

4: Favours trade liberalization with some infant-industry protections

5: Advocates free trade, full tariff reduction, removal of QRs, current account convertibility

Financial Sector:

1: Advocates bank nationalization, directed credit mandates, priority sector quotas, interest rate controls, FERA-style capital controls, restrictions on foreign banks

2: Supports government-directed finance; allows limited private role in non-priority areas

3: Descriptive or balanced

4: Favours financial sector competition, some interest rate flexibility, selective capital inflows

5: Advocates bank privatization, capital account convertibility, interest rate deregulation, FII investment, foreign bank entry

Fiscal Policy / PSEs:

1: Advocates large public sector as engine of growth, nationalization as policy tool, deficit financing for development, PSEs in commanding heights

2: Supports active state role in investment; favors PSE reform over privatization

3: Descriptive or balanced (e.g., advocates efficiency in PSEs without privatization stance)

4: Favours disinvestment/partial privatization, fiscal consolidation, PPP models

5: Advocates privatization, closing sick PSUs, private-sector-led growth, hard budget constraints

Other:

Score on whether the document favors government provision/regulation (1) vs. private/market mechanisms (5).

Appendix B: Pipeline Implementation Details

The measurement pipeline is implemented in Python. Stage 1 relevance filtering uses `gpt-5.4-mini` at temperature 0 with a binary relevance judgment prompt. Stage 2 ideology scoring uses the same model as the rubric described in Section 3.2, requesting JSON-structured output with keys `policy_area`, `ideology_score`, `confidence`, and `explanation`. The pipeline is resume-safe: each scored document is immediately written to a checkpoint file, and re-runs skip already-processed documents.